



Following a legend: In men's javelin throw, Ashish Yadav became the second Indian medallist after Neeraj Chopra as he clinched silver with an effort of 74.09m. PICS: GETTYIMAGES

(16th in men's discus throw qualification), Anshu (14th in women's shot put qualification) and Poonam (13th in women's javelin throw qualification) had not narrowly missed out on making the cut.

Eventually, India finished with two silver and a bronze medal — its joint-best performance at a single edition in terms of the number of medals, matching the tally from 2021 and 2022.

In men's javelin throw, Ashish Yadav became the second Indian medallist after Neeraj as he clinched silver with an effort of 74.09m, finishing behind South African Jan-Hendrik Heymans, who took the gold with a World U-20 leading throw of 80.50m. Yadav wasn't the only Indian in the 12-man final. T. Dharanidharan gave a good account of himself to secure the sixth spot with 72.35m.

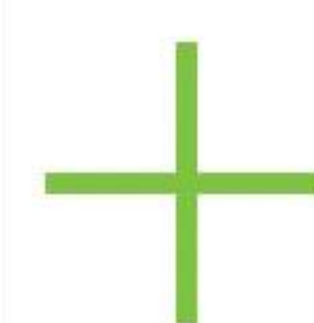
In men's high jump, Basant Kumar Meghwal created history as he became the first Indian medallist in the event at any world-level competition. The 19-year-old equalled his personal best jump of 2.21m and, while his jump was level with eventual gold medallist Younes Ayachi of Algeria, the Indian settled for silver after taking a single extra jump to clear the eventual mark.

In men's long jump, Shahnava proved that he is a talent to watch out for after bagging the bronze with a leap of 7.84m. He became the first Indian man to win a long jump medal at the World U-20 Championships. R.C. Jithin Arjunan, another Indian finalist, finished eighth with 7.59m.

There were some positive performances even though they did not end with a medal. Amanat Kamboj's sixth-place finish in women's discus throw came with a Personal Best of 53.24m.

Mohammed Ashfaq set a new U-20 National Record as he went sub-46 (45.81s) for the first time in his career during the 400m heats. In his semifinal, he clocked exactly 46 seconds and grabbed the third and last automatic qualification spot for the final. He may have stood a distant eighth with 46.20s in a nine-man final in which the top three went sub-45 but, nevertheless, Ashfaq's consistency is a big boost for the future.

One result, which was a tad disappointing, was Pooja's seventh-place finish in the women's high jump with a best clearance of 1.84m, nine centimetres short of her own senior National Record. Including the recent Commonwealth Games (Pooja finished eighth in



Indian medallists at World Athletics U-20 Championships

Seema Punia — Women's Discus Throw — Kingston, Jamaica, 2002

Navjeet Kaur Dhillon — Women's Discus Throw — Eugene, USA, 2014

Neeraj Chopra — Men's Javelin Throw — Bydgoszcz, Poland, 2016

Hima Das — Women's 400m — Tampere, Finland, 2018

Shaili Singh — Women's Long Jump — Nairobi, Kenya, 2021

Amit Khatri — Men's 10,000m Race Walk — Nairobi, Kenya, 2021

Mixed 4x400m Relay — Nairobi, Kenya, 2021

Mixed 4x400m Relay — Cali, Colombia, 2022

Selva Prabhu — Men's Triple Jump — Cali, Colombia, 2022

Rupal Chaudhary — Women's 400m — Cali, Colombia, 2022

Aarti — Women's 10,000m Race Walk — Lima, Peru, 2024

Ashish Yadav — Men's Javelin Throw — Eugene, USA, 2026

Basant Kumar Meghwal — Men's High Jump — Eugene, USA, 2026

Shahnava Khan — Men's Long Jump — Eugene, USA, 2026

Glasgow), it was her ninth competition of the year and perhaps fatigue played a role in her below-par performance.

The standards of global athletics are rising at a rapid pace. In such a scenario, it is important for this bunch of Indian youngsters to find the right kind of coaching, financial support and exposure to international competitions in order to take the next step, just like Neeraj did.